



PREFACE

When the present book was first published by St. Nikodemos the Hagiorite and St. Makarios Notaras, it had as its objective to elevate the spiritual life of Christians. At the same time, it was also a response to a certain attitude which had become the status quo, and an ideology, and which deterred Christians from their frequent participation in the divine communion of the immaculate Mysteries.

This matter was one of the basic subjects with which the so-called Philokalic movement of the eighteenth century was concerned. St. Nikodemos and St. Makarios are the most important representatives of the Philokalic movement, a movement of spiritual renewal within the Church. The period of Turkish oppression (1453–1821) had brought the spiritual life of the Christians of that time into decline. The most fundamental objectives of the movement were the observance of the sacred Canons, frequent participation in divine Communion, a return to the Fathers, the practice of noetic prayer, and the renewal of monasticism.

Even today we are living the reverberations of this movement of Fathers, most of whom have been acknowledged as Saints. And this is what sets it apart from the activity of

contemporary "modernists," who resort to innovations not founded upon the tradition of the Saints. The Saints are bearers of tradition, and it is in them that we place our trust when it comes to matters of the Church. They are those who are instructed and led by the Holy Spirit, expressing the truth of the Faith in every era. Certainly, every era requires its own mode of expression, but "the truth of the Lord abideth for ever" (Ps. 116:2).

Unfortunately, we can say that the status quo attitude was not overturned. Few were influenced by the Philokalic movement. The fruit of that struggle mainly appeared at the end of the nineteenth century and in the twentieth century. And only a portion of the people today can be characterized as being a part of the liturgical life of the Church, attending services, going to confession, and struggling in the spiritual life. Most of today's people are far from the Cup of life, and continue to offer the same justifications to excuse this lapse. Most Christians who do go to Church, but do not think it necessary to commune of the body and blood of Christ, are of the same attitude.

We live in a time of decline in ecclesiastical life. From the moment when most churchgoers wittingly and stubbornly abstain from divine Communion, we live in an ecclesiastical decline, for growth or decline is indicated by the participation of the faithful in this Mystery.

One time in a certain homily I told the people, "If you were to ask us priests when we will be pleased with our pastoral work, we would reply: 'Only when we reach the point that every Sunday during the Divine Liturgy all of the Christians have prepared themselves and receive Com-

munion, will we say that we are pleased with our pastoral work."

Academic theology systematically ignored, and largely still ignores, the Fathers of the Philokalic movement. As theology students, we never heard anything from a single one of our professors at the Theological School about this movement or about St. Nikodemos the Hagiorite. Now, finally, some interest has begun to appear, and this gives us hope. If only the academic theological world would also be irrigated by their theology, and if only the shepherds would offer the solid food of the Saints of the Philokalia to the spiritually needy.

Because of the prevailing condition we have described, Saints Nikodemos and Makarios's book, *Concerning Frequent Communion*, is highly relevant. This translation and publication in the English language will afford the faithful the ability to come into contact with the treasures of the Orthodox Faith and to be fed by the works of the Fathers of the Philokalia.

We hope that the publication of such books will help in overcoming our ecclesiastical decline.

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July 14, 2006

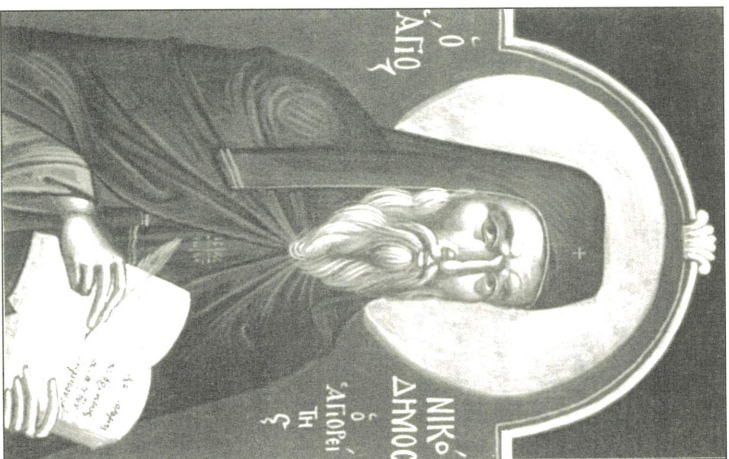
The Commemoration of St. Nikodemos the Hagiorite



A BRIEF HISTORY OF THE PRESENT BOOK¹

The first edition of this work had the following title: "A handbook, by an anonymous author, demonstrating that Christians must partake of the divine Mysteries more frequently. Now published for the first time and made possible at the expense of the most honorable and devout Mr. Demetrios Proskynetos of Drysta. Published in Venice, 1777, by Nicholas Glykes of Ioannina. Con Licenza de "Superiori."

It is considered as certain that the author hidden beneath the work's anonymity is St. Makarios Notaras. The biographer of this divine Father, St. Athanasios Parios, who also attributes the work's authorship to Makarios, offers the following brief analysis of it: "This work appears to contain nothing other than sayings from the Gospels, Apostles, Canons (Apostolic and Conciliar), and the divine Fathers, all explained in our popular dialect. They are all in accord and have the same conclusion, teaching that frequent reception of the divine Mysteries is good, holy, and salvific. Wherefore, this book is holy and lawful and canonical, because, as we said, it contains nothing other than scriptural, canonical, and



The Kollyvades Fathers

Saint Nikodemus the Hagiorite,
Saint Athanasios of Paros, Saint Makarios of Corinth

¹From Anthony N. Charokopos's *Ho Hagios Makarios ho Notaras, Metropolitan of Korinthou (1731–1805)* [St. Makarios Notaras, Metropolitan of Corinth (1731–1805)] (Athens: 2001), 182–188.

patristic sayings, interpreted and explained in the vernacular without a single distortion or mistake, as everyone can see."²

However, the work met with great resistance: "Even with all this," continues the biographer, "evil waxed mightily against it. When a certain evil-minded monk of the Holy Mountain received the book into his hands, thinking it was the work of Neophytos, he sent it via Thessaloniki to the Great Church in Constantinople, having a certain friend of his write as many bad things against it as he could. Patriarch Prokopios the Peloponnesian (1785–1789), who had then ascended the Patriarchal Throne from Smyrna, based solely on the accusations and criticisms regarding the book, was startled and without delay condemned the work synodically as unlawful and scandalous, meting out the severest penances to those who would dare read it. The brethren of Mt. Athos, through another individual, tried to repeal the condemnation of the book by means of a counter-decision of the Church, but they were unsuccessful. So the wrong remained uncorrected."³

However, via another reliable source, which published the patriarchal text,⁴ we are informed that the patriarch at

² Athanasios Parios, *Bios kai Politeia tou hosiou kai theophorou patros Makarion, Archiepiskopou Korinthou tou Notara [Life and Conduct of the Righteous and Godbearing Father Makarios Notaras, Archbishop of Corinth]*, in *Neon Chikon Lemnion*, 7th Edition, (Chios: 1992), 241.

³ Ibid. See also Tzoga, *He peri mnemonymon eris en Hagio Orei kala ton 18 aiona [The Controversy on the Holy Mountain During the 18th Century Concerning Memorial Services]* (Thessaloniki: 1969), 120–130.

⁴ Manuel J. Gedeon, *Kanonikai Diataxeis: Epistolai, Lyses, Thesphismata, ton hagiolaton Patriarchon Konstantinoupoleos. Apo Gregorion tou Theologou mechri Dionysiou tou apo Adrianoupoleos [Canonical Constitutions: Epistles, Solutions,*

that time was not Prokopios from Smyrna as the biographer writes, but Gabriel IV (1780–1785). This source cites a condemnation also by Prokopios, without citing the document, deriving its information from the biographer.⁵ We do not know if there was actually a second condemnation of the book. Perhaps the biographer was misled.

Here we add the entire lengthy patriarchal text:⁶

Gabriel, by the mercy of God Archbishop of Constantinople and New Rome and Ecumenical Patriarch.

Most-reverend Superintendents of the Community, former and current Abbots of our sacred and venerable Patriarchal and Stavropegic Monasteries of the Most-holy Mountain of Athos, and the rest of the Fathers dwelling in the monasteries, cells and sketes, our beloved children in the Lord: grace be with you and peace from God. To slip and fall into sins is terrible and damaging to the soul. But even more terrible, if not the most damaging, is when the fallen one does not want to get up and when the sinner does not repent or listen to advice unto his correction. The passions of sin are healed by the medicines of penitence and abstinence, but where these medicines are unable to have their effect, no hope of life remains. Therefore, those who are unrepentant are more wicked than those who are sinful and thus worthy of greater punishment and

Ordinances, of the Most-holy Patriarchs of Constantinople. From Gregory the Theologian to Dionysios of Adrianoupolis, supplement to "Ekklesiastikes Aitheias," vol. 1 (Constantinople: 1888), 269–272.

⁵ Ibid., 272.

⁶ Ibid., 269–272.

condemnation, in the same degree as incurable diseases are worse than curable ones. You, however, will not behave in such a manner, but you will rather amend your ways and obey the Great and Holy Church of Christ, and desist henceforth from your unreasonable disputes and quarrels. For there appeared before our Synod an anonymous book, *Concerning Sacred Communion*, already published and in print, and a letter stamped with the seal of your Community stating that on account of this book many quarrels and disputes have arisen and developed there. Some people accept it and say that it is necessary to partake of the immaculate Mysteries of Christ every day, in accordance with the thesis of the book; but other people oppose it and assert that one must first prepare many days beforehand through confession, self-control, and appropriate repentance, and then approach sacred Communion. These things, then, are contained in the letter of your Community. The book, being read and inspected, appeared at the first to be flawed and full of misunderstandings and absurdities, and then later as also contrary to the ecclesiastical good order and practice which has always been in effect. From time immemorial our Holy and blameless Church has never given the task of examining and adjudicating regarding the dogmas and sacred Mysteries to just anyone, or to any single person; but, rather, She knows that this is the work of a complete and supremely perfect council. And those things that have been approved and declared by the Church to be correct are given to the faithful for their use, as being beneficial to the soul. But the others are rightly disapproved and rejected as being erroneous and damaging to the soul, horrible and hateful to Christians, even if there is something correct in

them. Many times there have been men who have insidiously attempted to penetrate and corrupt correct and healthy things of our blameless Church, at the suggestion of the devil and under the pretense of piety and virtue. The writer of this little book, shamelessly and very boldly, with utter arrogance, went too far and took matters into his own hands, setting himself against ancient ecclesiastical good order and custom. And though he displayed the work to all, the author himself hid away in an unknown place and did not even place his own name on it. For, being conscious of the greatness of his sin and fearing chastisement and punishment, he concealed himself, in this way safely lying in wait, and then out of nowhere treacherously ambushing and springing upon the naive and the simple. For these reasons, then, this anonymous little book was deemed altogether outrageous and worthy of rejection, as incorrect and causing scandals, and also as being contrary to ancient ecclesiastical good order. Concerning the proper time for partaking of the divine and immaculate Mysteries, it is confessed [by us] that it is beneficial to receive Communion more frequently, if only it is done worthily. For our blameless faith knows that the worthy reception of Communion is necessary and among those things without which we cannot live. The proper time to receive Communion, as the great Father of the Church the sacred Chrysostom says, is not at the occasion of a Feast and celebration [as such], but when we have a pure conscience and a life free of evil deeds. And again, continuing, the same Father says: "Whenever you intend to partake of this Holy Offering, purify yourself many days beforehand through repentance and prayer and almsgiving, through occupying yourself with spiritual things, and by not returning to your

own vomit as does the dog."⁷ Therefore, according to the sacred Chrysostom and the divine Apostle, "Let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread, and drink of the cup" (1 Cor. 11:28). So, that the dissension, quarreling, the arrogant and unseasonable dispute caused by the aforementioned book shall cease, through the present letter, and with the agreement of the All-holy former Patriarchs of Constantinople, Ioannikios and Theodosios, and of His Beatitude and Holiness Patriarch Abramios, our dear and beloved brothers and concelebrants in the Holy Spirit, we, with the rest of our brethren and highly-honored and holy hierarchs, make a synodical declaration. We order all of you, as many as possess the aforementioned anonymous book concerning Communion, to immediately reject it and throw it away as being flawed and unlawful, without any of you daring to take it into his hands and read it—and so the exchange of words and disputes shall come to an end. Furthermore: Let nobody dare to write or say anything concerning matters that are not his concern; but, rather, all of you are to live and conduct yourselves in peace and concord in stillness, according to your profession, trusting in our synodical order and command. And may all those acting in this fashion as directed be forgiven and blessed by God the Lord Almighty and absolved and freed from the previously published penalties. However, whoever among you dares to write or speak from now on concerning these issues and disturbs the stillness of the Fathers in these places, as self-willed and disobedient to our patriarchal and synodical commands and as a rebel and lover of disturbance

⁷ *De Beato Philogonio* 4, PG 48, 755.

and causer of scandals, let him be anathematized, etc. (the usual curses). Let it be so by decree.

1785. In the month of April. Third Indiction.

Former Patriarch of Constantinople Ioannikios co-decrees.

Abramios of Jerusalem co-decrees. Samuel of Ephesus.

Methodios of Herakleia. Agapios of Kylikos. Gerasimos of

Nikomedeia. Parthenios of Chalcedon. Ananias of Derkos.

Mathew of Serres. Gregory of Drama. Meletios of Nauplioion.

Later, however, the book was vindicated, as is apparent from the epistle of Patriarch Neophytos VII (1789–1798 and 1798–1801) written between the years 1789–1794 to the most-holy Father, Makarios. This epistle of the patriarch "to the former Metropolitan of Corinth," published by the biographer of the illustrious hierarch,⁸ reads as follows:

Most-sacred former Metropolitan of Corinth Makarios, beloved in the Spirit and concelebrant with our Mediocrity, grace be with your arch-priesthood and peace from God. Concerning the written work of your arch-priesthood, the book concerning frequent sacred Communion, which you published in print, we make known to you that it was examined synodically, carefully inspected, and approved and confirmed as ecclesiastically lawful and as containing no impediment as to its use. However, those who worthily desire to frequently partake of the immaculate and dread Mysteries must do so through repentance and true confession. And when they frequently commune with this lawful and God-pleasing preparation, frequent communion is very

⁸ Parios, 241–242. See also Papouliades, 57.

lawful and beneficial to the soul and salvific. Therefore, your book was synodically declared beneficial and salvific, since it demonstrates this lawful manner of receiving Communion, and those wishing to buy it may read it unhindered, and they may receive Communion with the fear of God, lawfully and canonically, with the guidance and satisfaction [of the assigned spiritual rule] of each person's Spiritual Father. These are worthy to receive frequently. However, because a suspicion has grown that an ecclesiastical excommunication has been pronounced condemning your written work, and therefore, in order to respect the "excommunication," pious Christians do not read it, we write in this present letter and declare through the All-holy and Officiating Spirit the dissolution of these ecclesiastical bonds and penalties: "All those Christians desiring to read your synodically examined written work, that is, your book concerning frequent Communion, are forgiven and blessed by God the Lord Almighty, being no longer constrained by the ecclesiastical penalties and having no curses; they even have the prayers and blessings of all the Saints and holy people and God-bearing Fathers of the Church through all the centuries. Therefore, Your Sacredness, dismiss every mistrust and suspicion about your work, since you will receive reward from God for your written work, being as it is beneficial to the soul, and may His grace be with you."

Before the book's acquittal, the divine Makarios, on account of the manifest resistance against it, gave the work over to St. Nikodemos the Hagiorite for it to be worked on further and revised. So the work was republished after six

years in 1783 by St. Nikodemos with the title: "A book most profitable to the soul concerning frequent Communion of the immaculate Mysteries of Christ. Now published for the first time unto the common benefit of Orthodox Christians. Published in Venice, 1783, by Anthony Bertoli. Con Licenza de 'Superiori e Rivilegio."⁹ This book also contains an explanation of the Lord's Prayer, which is absent from the 1777 edition. Evidently, this work too was published anonymously, but it is considered certain that Nikodemos the Hagiorite is its author, the one responsible for the revision, the enriching amendments, and the additions to the text of the 1777 edition.¹⁰

In that we wish to be as thorough as possible, we note that, concerning the authorship of the work, or rather, of the works—that is, of the 1777 edition and of the 1783 edition—there has arisen a literary controversy.¹¹ We will not proceed here with an analysis of the controversy, but simply note in brief the opinions of the researchers.

Most attribute the 1777 edition to Makarios of Corinth (L. Petit, S. Makres, K. Doukakes, J. Konstantinides, N. Zacharopoulos, and G. Berites), and the reworked 1783

⁹ Theokletos Dionysiates, *Hagios Nikodemos ho Hagiorites: Ho bios kai ta erga tou* (1749–1809) [*St. Nikodemos the Hagiorite: His Life and Works* (1749–1809)], (Athens: 1959), 110 ff.

¹⁰ For an analysis see: *Hierod. Neophytou Kausokalybiou, Peri tes sychnes Metalepseos, Eisagoge – Keimenon (anekdoton) – Scholia* [*Hierodeacon Neophytos Kausokalybius, Concerning Frequent Communion, Introduction – Text (unpublished) – Scholia*], Hieromonk Theodoret the Hagiorite, 2nd ed. (Athens: 1992), 7 ff. where there is also an analytical bibliography – references.

¹¹ Dionysiates, 110. This viewpoint is contested by K. K. Papoulides (133, n93).

edition to Nikodemos the Hagiorite in collaboration with the sacred Makarios (basically all of the aforementioned), or only to Nikodemos (M. Gedeon, who also presented a modified viewpoint).¹² Others (H. Hodges and others)

¹² Translator's note: The early biographers of St. Nikodemos, such as Euthymios (1812) and Onouphrios Ivirites (1819), and the more recent biographers, such as Gerasimos Mikragiannanites (1955) and Theokletos Dionysiates (1959), all agree that St. Nikodemos received the book in its original form from St. Makarios (whoever its original author might have been), but then edited, corrected, and expanded it. Furthermore, St. Nikodemos himself witnesses to the fact that he wrote it, defending it as his own in the *Apologia* he wrote almost thirty years later (*Homologia Pistos* [*Confession of Faith*], written in 1807, but published posthumously at Venice in 1819). The final form as we have received it is undoubtedly from the pen of St. Nikodemos. Nevertheless, it is a definite product of the "school" of the *Kollyvades*, as are all the works of St. Nikodemos. He was not a freelance writer expressing his private opinion, but always received assignments from holy men such as St. Makarios, writing everything with a blessing. It is also worth noting here what Dr. George Bebis writes concerning this work:

The book was not authored originally by St. Nikodemos himself. Father Theokletos Dionysiates has expressed the opinion that it came from the pen of the Hagiorite monk Neophytos, who was one of the protagonists of the *Kollyvades*. Recently, the Hagiorite monk Theodore has discovered the original manuscript of Neophytos in the library of the Academy of Bucharest, Roumania, dated in 1772, as well as the first printed edition made in the more popular language, which was edited in 1777. Father Theodore has proved beyond any doubt that St. Nikodemos' edition in 1783 was based on Neophytos' work. St. Makarios encouraged his friend to undergo a revision of this splendid book, and St. Nikodemos revised, enlarged, and enriched Neophytos' original work to such an extent that it may almost be considered a new book. St. Nikodemos extended the original 173 pages to 343. He wrote two introductions, and divided the book into

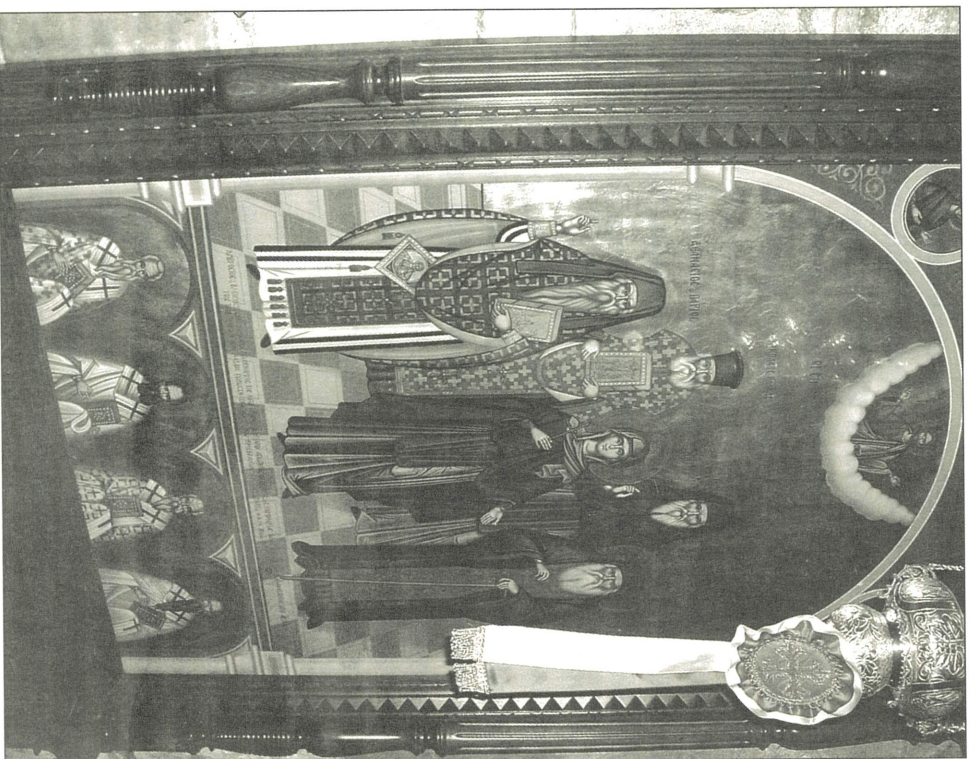
maintain that the 1783 edition belongs entirely to Makarios of Corinth. Theokletos Dionysiates attributes the 1777 edition to Neophytos Kavsoakalyvites.¹³ This opinion is mainly supported by Hieromonk Theodore the Hagiorite, who also published Neophytos' original work, "as preserved until now in codices no. 988, 225a-261b and no. 192, 19a-60b of the Academy of Bucharest"¹⁴ (1st ed., 1975; 2nd ed., 1992). A work by Neophytos Kavsoakalyvites concerning frequent Communion of the immaculate Mysteries was reportedly published in 1766 (A. Demetrakopoulos and C. Patineles), but according to Theodore the Hagiorite, this has not been proven as of yet.¹⁵ And S. Papadopoulos speaks of two books, one by Neophytos Kavsoakalyvites, which was composed in 1772 and published, as is verified by Hieromonk Theodore, and the other of St. Makarios.

three parts. In the first part, in nine chapters, he analyzes and interprets the Lord's Prayer (not found in Neophytos' book); in the second part, he speaks about the need for frequent holy Communion; and, in the third part, in the form of questions and answers, he refutes the arguments of his opponents that frequent holy Communion is not proper and necessary. (*Nikodemos of the Holy Mountain: A Handbook of Spiritual Counsel* [New York: Paulist Press, CWS, 1989], 24-25)

¹³ Hierod. Neophytou Kausokalybition, *Peri tes sychnes Metalebseos, Eisagoge - Keimenon (anekdoton) - Scholia* [Hierodetacem Neophytos Kavsoakalyvites, *Concerning Frequent Communion, Introduction - Text (unpublished) - Scholia*], Hieromonk Theodore the Hagiorite, 2nd Edition (Athens: 1992).

¹⁴ Ibid., 10. For the opinion of C. Patineles and the others mentioned above, see *Ekdolitikes Athenon, Historia tou Hellenikou Ethnous* [Athens Editorial, *History of the Greek Nation*], vol. 11, 132.

¹⁵ Papouides, 59-60. See also the sacred service of our Holy and Godbearing Father Christodoulos the Wonderworker, 5th ed. (Athens: 1957), 5.



The Saints of the Islands of Paros and Naxos

(L-R) *Saint Athanasios of Paros, Saint Nicolas Planas, Saint Theoklitos, Saint Nikodemos the Hagiorite and Saint Philotheos Zervakos.*

ABBREVIATIONS

ACW	Ancient Christian Writers.
ANF	Anti-Nicene Fathers.
CSCO	Corpus Scriptorum Christianorum Orientalium.
CWS	The Classics of Western Spirituality.
FC	Fathers of the Church.
GrPhilokalia	Philokalia of the Sacred Nephic Fathers, ed. St. Nikodemos the Hagiorite and St. Makarios Notaras, Venice, 1782.
NPNF	Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers.
PG	Patrologia Graeca.
The Philokalia	The Philokalia: The Complete Text, trans. and ed. G. E. H. Palmer, P. Sherrard, K. Ware, London and Boston, 1979 (volume 1), 1981 (volume 2), 1984 (volume 3), 1995 (volume 4).
PL	Patrologia Latina.
ST	Studi e Testi.
SC	Sources Chrétiennes, Paris.